

Report Part Title: The Political Decision-Making:

Report Title: Europe Rediscovered Peacekeeping?

Report Subtitle: Political and Military Logics in the 2006 UNIFIL Enhancement

Report Author(s): Alexander Mattelaer

Egmont Institute (2009)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.com/stable/resrep06671.6>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



Egmont Institute is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to this content.

JSTOR

The Political Decision-Making: What to Do and Who Does What?

The war between Israel and Hezbollah and the following deployment of extra peacekeepers did not come out of the blue. Since its inception in 1978, in the midst of the Lebanese civil war and the context of the Arab-Israeli conflict, the outlook of UNIFIL has constantly evolved in response to local circumstances.³ UNIFIL's troop strength went up and down several times as the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) repeatedly occupied southern Lebanon to deal with threats posed by Arab militants. When Israel unilaterally withdrew from Lebanon in 2000, Hezbollah filled the resulting power vacuum. This Shia organisation, inspired by the Iranian revolution, developed into a quasi-state within the state of Lebanon. It built up territorial defences as well as provided social services to the population.⁴ Continuing disputes over the demarcation of the Lebanese-Israeli border as well as over the fate of the Palestinian refugees created by the 1948 Arab-Israeli war provided fuel for keeping conflict alive from one decade to the next. The tense stand-off in the following years abruptly escalated on 12 July 2006, when Hezbollah fighters conducted a raid across the Blue Line – the unofficial border defined by the UN – kidnapping two Israeli soldiers and killing three others and launched rocket fire on Haifa, Israel's third largest city. In response, the Israeli cabinet immediately authorised a sharp military response. This resulted in 34 days of fighting but produced no decisive result. By combining guerrilla warfare with conventional, in-depth territorial defence, Hezbollah managed to survive and – to some degree – resist the onslaught by Israeli forces.

International public outcry over the war came swiftly. As both France – the former colonial power in Lebanon – and the US – Israel's main ally – gave their full diplomatic attention to the crisis, and as UNIFIL was already present on the ground, the UN Security Council proved to be the key negotiating table for hammering out a deal for halting the conflict. While the idea of deploying an international force started circulating quickly,⁵ opinions widely diverged on what kind of force was required. Suggestions for expanding UNIFIL arose early on, but the US and – at least initially – France first proposed a robust interven-

3. A detailed history of UNIFIL since its inception and the context in which it operated lies far beyond the scope of this paper. For further reading, see B. Skogmo, *UNIFIL: International Peacekeeping in Lebanon, 1978-1988*, Boulder, Lynne Rienner, 1989; and J. Hillen, *Blue Helmets: The Strategy of UN Military Operations*, Washington DC, Brassey's, 2000.

4. See A.R. Norton, *Hezbollah: A Short History*, Princeton, Princeton UP, 2009.

5. It has even been suggested that Israeli leaders from early on in the war counted on the insertion of an international intervention force as an exit strategy to disengage from the fighting; see Z. Schiff, 'Israel's War with Iran', in *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 85, 2006, No. 6, pp. 23-31; and J. Bolton, *Surrender is not an Option: Defending America at the United Nations and Abroad*, New York, Threshold Editions, 2007, p. 402.

tion force with enforcement authority under Chapter VII of the UN Charter.⁶ On 26 July, at an international conference in Rome, the Lebanese government put forward a seven-point proposal, calling for the enhancement of UNIFIL and committing the Government of Lebanon to deploying the Lebanese Armed Forces (LAF) to southern Lebanon and exercising its full sovereignty. In response, Israeli Prime Minister Olmert stated that Israel would require a 15,000 strong international force made up of 'real soldiers and not pensioners' before giving up control over the terrain it occupied.

On 5 August, France and the US tabled a draft resolution that still mentioned the option of a Chapter VII international force, but subjected it to both Israeli and Lebanese approval. Reportedly, Lebanese Prime Minister Siniora pushed hard for a more restrictive mandate in order to avoid provoking Hezbollah in the domestic political arena.⁷ For the Lebanese government, only an expanded UN force was acceptable – de facto killing the idea of a multinational force not under UN command. On 9 August, Israeli Prime Minister Olmert informed the US that it would accept the plan for an enhanced UNIFIL.⁸ After the UN Secretary-General assured the US that a robust mandate could be written without reference to Chapter VII, all obstacles to a deal were cleared.

On 11 August 2006, the Security Council unanimously adopted Resolution 1701, co-drafted by France and the US. It welcomed the Lebanese government's decision to extend its authority over its territory and send up to 15,000 LAF troops to the south. It not only called for a full cessation of hostilities, but also for a long-term solution, based on the principles of full respect for the Blue Line, the absence of weapons other than those of the Lebanese government and UNIFIL in the area between the Blue Line and the Litani river, and the full implementation of Resolution 1559, i.e. requiring the disarmament of all armed groups. Regarding the enhanced UNIFIL itself, the Security Council authorised an increase in troops to a maximum of 15,000. Its mandate included the following tasks:

- Confirm the withdrawal of Israeli forces
- Restore international peace and security

6. After all, there was a historical precedent for this option as well: in 1982 a multinational force (MNF) consisting of US, French, Italian and British troops deployed to west Beirut in response to Israel's second invasion of Lebanon and the ensuing massacres in the Sabra and Chatila refugee camps. However, the MNF gradually got drawn into the dynamic of the Lebanese civil war and ended in disaster when suicide bombers killed more than 300 US marines and French paratroopers. See A. McDermott and K. Skjelsbaek, eds., *The Multinational Force in Beirut 1982-1984*, Miami, Florida International UP, 1991.

7. See *Lebanon: Hizbollah's Weapons Turn Inward*, Beirut/Brussels, International Crisis Group Middle East Briefing N° 23.

8. Bolton, op. cit., p. 408.

- Assist the Government of Lebanon in ensuring the return of its effective authority in the area⁹
- Monitor the cessation of hostilities
- Accompany and support the LAF
- Coordinate its activities in support of the LAF with the Government of Lebanon and the Government of Israel
- Extend its assistance to help ensure humanitarian access to civilian populations and the voluntary and safe return of displaced persons
- Assist the LAF in taking steps towards the establishment of an area free of any armed personnel, assets and weapons other than those of the Government of Lebanon and UNIFIL
- Assist the Government of Lebanon, at its request, to secure its border to prevent illegal arms trafficking

Furthermore, UNIFIL was authorised to take all necessary action to ensure that its area of operations is not utilised for hostile activities, to ensure the security and freedom of movement of UN personnel and humanitarian workers and to protect civilians under imminent threat of physical violence. This single document constituted both the starting point for the operational planning process and the political reference framework for the entire further operation.

Already early on in the diplomatic process, questions surfaced on how this international force would be commanded and who would contribute to it. While Lebanese opposition ruled out any non-UN force, the Israeli government insisted on the participation of European armed forces. This posed an organisational problem: most European states had left the framework of UN peacekeeping as a result of the traumatic experiences in the former Yugoslavia. In order to overcome this problem, France, which was initially expected to take the lead of the operation, initiated what would become a heated argument with the UN Secretariat. Contrary to the regular command structure of the UN Department of Peacekeeping Operations (DPKO) – where the political headquarters directly instructs the operational headquarters in the field – France insisted on having a strategic command level in place. Out of mistrust of the DPKO, France, soon followed by Italy and Spain, insisted on having a European four star general that could command the operation in crisis situations. During bilateral talks in Paris between France and UN Under-Secretary-General for Peacekeeping Jean-Marie Guéhenno a deal was struck that a special military command for UNIFIL could be set up in New York. As Guéhenno returned to New York, however, this deal proved too hard to swallow for the UN Secretariat, which was not willing to give up the command of the operation. As France had already publicly commit-

9. These first three tasks formed the original mandate of UNIFIL as set out in Resolution 425.

ted itself to participating in the operation, Paris felt cheated by the UN's resistance and responded by offering only 200 extra troops in an attempt to force their proposal through.

The eventual compromise was to set up a special Strategic Military Cell (SMC) in New York. This would be a dedicated military structure mainly staffed by officers from the troop contributing countries. Contrary to what France and other Europeans wanted, however, it would not be part of the command chain: the 'Director' of the SMC would be the focal point for military advice, but not a real commander. In theory, its purpose was to augment the strategic planning support of DPKO; in practice, its most important function was to allow for increased oversight by the European troop contributors.¹⁰ At the political-strategic level, therefore, UNIFIL would remain under the authority of the UN Under-Secretary General for Peacekeeping. Within the DPKO structure, the SMC would take over all UNIFIL-related military work from the DPKO Office of Military Affairs with the exception of force generation. However, the DPKO Office of Operations would remain responsible for the political oversight of the operation. Not unimportant is the fact that the Under-Secretary-General only issues guidance to the operational level after consultations with and consent of all relevant DPKO units. Considering the heterogeneity of the UN staff, it can be argued that the UN bureaucracy not only supports the political decision-making in the Security Council, but also becomes an important part of the political process itself.

Once it became clear that the UN could offer special procedural flexibility to potential UNIFIL troop contributors, the door for substantial European involvement lay wide open. On 21 August, after a personal request by the Israeli Prime Minister, Italian Prime Minister Prodi announced Italy was ready to take the lead. On 24 August, French President Chirac announced 1,600 extra troops after receiving "a certain number of guarantees for the conditions of efficiency and optimal security of our troops".¹¹ Interestingly, the debate over force contributions, the details of which will be discussed in the next subsection, featured a remarkable degree of multilateralism, involving Israel and Lebanon as well as the EU. The EU dynamic relative to the crisis in Lebanon became most visible at an extraordinary meeting of the General Affairs and External Relations Council on 25 August. At this event, the EU foreign ministers held an exchange of views with UN Secretary-General Kofi Annan and formalised their offers for UNIFIL contributions. In the end, contributions from EU countries would exceed 7,600

10. For an in-depth discussion of the SMC, see R. Hatto, 'UN Command and Control Capabilities: Lessons from UNIFIL's Strategic Military Cell', in: *International Peacekeeping*, Vol. 16, 2009, No. 2, pp. 186-198.

11. Quoted in the *Financial Times*, 'France pledges 1,600 troops for Lebanon', 25 August 2006.

troops, or more than half of UNIFIL personnel.¹² This put the Council in a position to claim a leadership role for the Union in UNIFIL.

Only days after the adoption of Resolution 1701, the DPKO circulated drafts of the key planning documents. On this basis, a meeting for troop-contributing countries was held on 17 August. The speed with which the deployment eventually took place surpassed expectations – underscoring what becomes possible if sufficient political will is present. On the one hand, this was made possible because the regular UN procedures were loosened with the aim of facilitating rapid deployment, for example waiving the requirement for signing a memorandum of understanding in advance.¹³ On the other hand, the European troop contributors by and large made use of their own means for putting boots on the ground rather than relying on UN logistics. On 2 September, for example, Italian marines conducted an amphibious landing on the beaches of Tyre. One planner jokingly spoke of a ‘race to Lebanon’.

In drawing up the UNIFIL force requirements, which originally numbered some 12,300 troops, the structure of the enhanced UNIFIL would come to look as follows.¹⁴ The area of operations was divided in two sectors (West and East) which would each feature a brigade-sized mechanised infantry force, which would be supported by a quick reaction force and appropriate combat support and combat service support elements. Italy would take the lead of Sector West, which would be composed of battalions from France, Ghana, Italy and Korea; whereas Spain would take the lead of Sector East, which would be composed of battalions from India, Indonesia, Nepal and Spain. France would provide the Quick Reaction Force, with artillery units and main battle tanks for extra firepower. Italy, Tanzania, Belgium, China, Portugal, Turkey and France would provide combat support units (rotary aviation, engineering and military police), whereas Ghana, Poland, Belgium and China would provide combat service support (logistics and medical).

One important innovation in the enhanced UNIFIL, however, was the addition of a Maritime Task Force (MTF). During the war, Israel had imposed a maritime blockade on Lebanon in order to cut off maritime arms smuggling. The blockade, which was having a heavy impact on the Lebanese economy, was to be lifted as part of the ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon. In order to counter

12. For a more extensive discussion of the individual positions of the EU ‘big three’ (France, Germany and the UK), see E. Gross, *The Europeanization of National Foreign Policy: Continuity and Change in European Crisis Management*, Basingstoke, Palgrave Macmillan, 2009.

13. One UN official explained there was also an aspect of bureaucratic politics to this. The UN Secretary-General was nearing the end of his tenure and reportedly did not want to finish upon unfinished business.

14. What follows is a general outline of the force structure as it would come to look in 2007 when the expansion was completed (based on an unclassified UN briefing obtained by the author).

maritime arms smuggling, as requested by Israel, the Lebanese government asked for UN assistance in monitoring and patrolling its territorial waters. As this also offered an opportunity for contributing to UNIFIL without putting boots on the ground – i.e. at a lower level of political risk – the plan emerged to complement UNIFIL ground forces with a maritime task force. The MTF would have a maritime interdiction mission in an area stretching nearly fifty nautical miles off the Lebanese coast, for which four frigates, three support ships and a number of fast patrols boats and maritime surveillance aircraft would be required. The lead was taken by Germany, which was keen on showing its support of Israel but wary of arriving in a situation where the Bundeswehr would come face-to-face with the IDF on the ground. For the UN system in general, the MTF was groundbreaking as it was the first time a UN operation included naval assets.